Amazon Echo Auto

CES was the first time everyone got to experience a drive with Alexa coming along for a ride. Amazon did showcase the Echo Auto, Amazon's way of integrating Alexa into your car in September 2018. It's still an invite-only system to get your hands on one. At CES, Amazon wasn't showcasing the add-in Echo Auto but more of a native integration of Alexa into cars. Amazon is working with car manufacturers to figure out how to provide the best possible experience with Alexa in cars. In an environment where anything can end up being a distraction, Amazon has to tread clearly with how they implement this new feature. We experienced this in a BMW 530E, which is one of the first vehicles to natively integrate Alexa. In this case, it was built into the BMW iDrive 6.x software.

The microphone to activate Alexa is placed in the ceiling of the car right above the driver's seat. This helps the microphone to clearly pickup the voice commands without all the ambient noise drowning out the driver. Moreover, the sensitivity of the microphone was tuned such that it picks up the driver's voice clearly but the passengers could hardly trigger them.

IBM Q System One

IBM revealed the IBM Q System One, a 20-Qubit quantum computer has been designed for scientific and commercial use outside the research laboratories. IBM also announced that it would open its first IBM Q Quantum Computation Centre for commercial clients in Poughkeepsie, New York sometime in 2019.

The IBM Q System One will combine classical and quantum computing elements into a single integrated architecture that is modular and designed for stability, reliability and continuous commercial use. The Q System One is designed to be stable and with the ability to auto calibrate in order to provide repeatable and predictable high-quality qubits. It reportedly delivers a continuous cold and isolated quantum environment which allows it to control a large number of qubits.

The IBM Q System One would allow for modeling some physics and chemical systems. Given that IBM is the first to have a commercial quantum computer solution, it certainly has a significant lead over the competition.

NVIDIA RTX 2060 and 20-series mobile chips

NVIDIA's CES 2019 press conference turned out to be a bit different this year. NVIDIA CEO Jensen Huang came onto the stage and set the record straight from the get go, this year's CES was going to be all about gaming. Jensen Huang's keynote shared quite a few similarities with his Gamescom 2018 address, it started off with him revisiting the graphics revolution seen in the past 15 years and how it was primarily focused on rasterization in the past and the shift towards more real time processing. It wouldn't take a rocket scientist to figure out that we were about to see the announcement of a new graphics card with real-time ray-tracing capabilities.

NVIDIA announced the latest member in the RTX family, the NVIDIA GeForce RTX 2060. The RTX 2060 will reportedly rival the previous gen GTX 1080 in terms of performance. Unlike predictions made by industry analysts, the RTX 2060 does indeed have 30 RT cores giving it real-time ray-tracing capabilities.

Another major announcement was the introduction of the new mobility GPU lineup based on the Turing architecture. GeForce RTX-powered laptops will be available starting Jan. 29 from the world's top OEMs, including Acer, Alienware, ASUS, Dell, Gigabyte, HP, Lenovo Legion, MSI, Razer and Samsung. The individual manufacturers will be unveiling their SKUs in the coming days.